

Readings

"Pleasure" - The Book of Qualities by J. Ruth Gendler

Pleasure is wild and sweet. She likes purple flowers. She loves the sun and the wind and the night sky. She carries a silver bowl full of liquid moonlight. She has a cat named Midnight with stars on his paws.

Many people mistrust Pleasure, and even more misunderstand her. For a long time I could hardly stand to be in the same room with her. I went to sleep early to avoid her. I thought she was a gossip and a flirt and she drank too much. In school we learned that she was dangerous, and I was sure that she would distract me from my work. I didn't realize she could nurture me.

As I have changed, Pleasure has changed. I have learned to value her friendship.

Meister Eckhart

If the only prayer you ever say in your whole life is, "Thank you," it is enough.

Abundance

I heard two stories this last week about people saving things for a rainy day. One was a story of a young woman. She had bought a lovely piece of lingerie. It was a satin and silk affair with hand tatted lace. It cost her a great deal of money. And this beautiful garment was kept wrapped in tissue and carefully placed in a drawer of her dresser. She never wore it. She was saving it for a special occasion.

The other story was of an old woman who had lived her whole life on a farm. She had lived through the Great Depression, worked hard all her life, scrimped and saved. She had a complete set of wedgewood dinner ware. Exquisitely crafted plates and bowls and cups and saucers. She kept them carefully packaged in their original carton and stored on a shelf in the back of a pantry. She was saving them for a special day.

The lingerie, with the price tag still on it, and the wedgewood tableware were found by relatives. Both the young woman and the old lady had died, never having used these treasures. They never took them out for a special day.

It reminds me of scarcity. Scarcity is an outlook, an attitude, a mentality. It is rooted in our fears. It thrives on any disappointment.

Scarcity is how we try to protect our hearts and our interests. We become miserly with our time. We keep our emotions and affections close to our chest. We don't want to share them, we could get hurt. We find that we are calculating, giving out only bits of information. We don't want others to know too much, or it could be used against us

Our energy, our goods, our money, our space, our ideas, our enthusiasm, all must be hoarded and preserved. We save things, careful not to waste them. Maybe we'll take them out on a special day.

But what is so fascinating about this attitude of scarcity is that it is not founded on how much we actually have. People who are obscenely wealthy can be just as miserly as people in poverty. It is based on our fears, not our circumstances.

And likewise, a mentality of abundance is not determined by our life situations.

I believe that on some levels, scarcity or abundance is a choice, a very spiritual choice.

Now, as I say this, I am acutely aware of the times in my life when I have been in extreme distress. I have been in severe financial constraints,

emotionally depleted, and sorely pressed for time. And then some spiritual yocal comes along and tells me that I am just focused on my fears and my mindset of scarcity. I'm told I should turn my thinking around, be more positive and optimistic! "Think abundance and you'll have abundance!" I hate it when someone tells me these things. I feel blamed. As though I don't feel bad enough all ready, I'm then told that these feelings of fear and insecurity and self-protection are wrong. I just need to be more "spiritual" - then the abundance will come.

So today, as we examine the principle of abundance, we want to try to do some careful balancing. We will look at abundance, in all its glory and freedom, and we will be honest in our own lives about our own mentality. We will ask ourselves, "Is this just our mindset getting in our way, or are we dealing with a genuine problem?"

I would rather we be wooed by the promises of abundance, than punished for feeling our fears. So look with me at this spiritual principle of abundance.

Have you ever had the experience of so many good things coming your way, you were overwhelmed? There are times, when life seems so right, when our faith floats on clouds, when joy and fullness and contentment are facts. There are genuine experiences of prosperity. Having a mentality of abundance is easy during those times.

Though, even when the riches rain down, some of us are still prone to say "Things are going so well, I wonder when the other shoe is going to drop."

But how do we have an attitude of plenty when life is just rather regular? And do we really want to? Could we be setting ourselves up for a fall? Is the risk of abundance really worth it all?

Let's start with the how. How do we go about this?

Gratitude is the place to start. This is the beginning. The more we give thanks, the more we start to notice all there is to give thanks for. Above all else, gratitude is the greatest factor in abundance. Each time we pause and notice the good in the world and the good in our lives, we remind ourselves that there is enough goodness to go around

People who say "Thank You" not only show good manners, saying "Thank You" reminds us that we are being taken care of. Our needs and our wants are being attended to. Gratitude fosters in us the realization that things are really ok, at least in some areas. And if life is good in one area, we then have hope for other parts of our lives.

Abundance is not merely the idea of getting more into our lives. Abundance is first learning to notice, appreciate, and value the goodness that is already there, the goodness which surrounds us in so many different forms.

If you want to live with an outlook of plenty, begin with gratitude.

A second step in developing an attitude of abundance is simplicity. Sorting out our rooms, our closets, our homes, our time, our days, keeping those things and activities which are meaningful and discarding those things we do not want or need adds to feelings of abundance.

Interesting, isn't it? As we get rid of clutter and junk, time wasters and space takers, we surround ourselves with those things we love and we spend more of our time doing those things we enjoy.

Abundance isn't about getting more stuff into your life. It's about having a life that is content and full of what brings us joy.

At our house, on our refrigerator, Bob and I have a plaque that reads "Have nothing in your home that you do not know to be useful or believe to beautiful." This little saying has kept us from buying so much stuff we don't need and helped us get rid of a great deal of stuff we don't really want. Abundance through simplicity.

Along those same lines, order adds to our feelings of posterity. When our possessions are in a jumble, when our living and working space is chaotic, when our lives are horribly messy, we are distracted from the goodness we have. Clutter gets in our way. When we have order and stability, we can then begin to see and realize our abundance.

For example, If I misplace an important sheet of paper, and then spend the next 45 minutes looking for it, I have just lost 45 minutes where I could have been doing something that I do enjoy!

Order allows us to appreciate what we have in our lives.

Another aspect of abundance is slowing down and using the pauses in our days. When we take the time to notice, we begin to see so much more. When we are busy and rushed, or when we are preoccupied with our negative thoughts we miss out on so much. By slowing down, we become aware of what is around us and all the excellence we so often miss.

Last fall, I was driving along, busy thinking hard about something. Then I noticed that along the left side of the highway, blocked in on both sides, was a thin strip of velvet, green grass. It was lush and verdant and startling. In the middle of an asphalt highway, with little chance of water and surely no clean air, this beautiful strip of grass was growing and thriving.

It reminded me that even in ugliness, there is beauty. It reminded me that a good quality of life can be had, even in less than favorable circumstances. I was encouraged, cheered, hopeful, and a bit tickled by this momentary sighting. This small pause changed my whole day. I was reminded of abundance.

One last thing you can do to increase the plenty in your life is to give. Give your time, your money, your energy, your emotions, your humor - give what you can, when you can, and do so thoughtfully.

There is an old spiritual principle that as you give, so shall you receive. Remember pledging to your church, giving to charities? It is not a spiritual exercise aimed at increasing discipline. Rather, when we give, we are preparing ourselves to receive.

A while back, I was listening to a woman who is an expert at handling money. She has successfully made her way by helping other people learn how to manage their money and increase their fiscal worth. In her presentation, this woman claimed that one of the best things a person can do with their money is to give some of it away. I thought of all those sermons I heard on pledging!

She did not approach giving from a spiritual angle. Instead, she had learned that when people give away money, they tend to get back even more. Her theory was that this happens because when we give some money away, we usually begin to feel better about ourselves and feel more in control of our lives. We can then create, or move into, new positions because of our new found confidence in ourselves and in abundance. While it wasn't a particularly spiritual explanation, it illustrated the fact that even non-religious people are learning what we have known for years: As you give, so shall you get! And that relates to abundance.

Finally, the most important matter in cultivating a mentality of abundance is our focus. What do we pay attention to in our lives? What is it that we focus on? If we spend our time examining and dwelling on all the things that are not how we want them to be, we can be assured that we will not be ready to receive the plenty which envelopes us.

But if we are conscious of all in our lives that really is right, we will be well on our way. If you see the good, you will come to expect and trust more good. If you concentrate on the bad, that is what you will come to expect.

We are meant to have life, and to have it more abundantly. That doesn't boil down to having more things. It means that we will enjoy what we do have with contentment, fulfillment, and joy.

If you want to increase an attitude of abundance in your lives, start by being grateful, for every little good thing you can. Learn how to breath a "Thank You," with your very breath

Simplify your environment and activities. Don't letter clutter keep you from serenity.

Bring order into your home. You'll have more time to enjoy your days.

Learn to notice all the beauty and goodness which abounds. The more you notice, the more you will see.

And be sure to be giving in your abundance. Hoarding does not befit the soul

And above all, focus. Set your sights to that which is lovely and rich and grand, even the small things that are truly wonderful.

I invite you to try out these ideas. See if they work for you. And I even offer a guarantee. If you aren't satisfied with abundance, your misery will be returned to you in full! Let us rejoice in the goodness which surrounds us.

Amen and Amen..